The Care Gaps Review Checklist

What to gather, compare and ask about the help Dad actually gets.

Dad has a care plan, an agency on the calendar and a sister who fills in. Before anyone says something is missing, make sure you have these in hand. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is a job for this week, not a finding about Dad's care.

Gather

- [ ] The care plan, and any assessment or summary you were given, in writing, with the date on each.
- [ ] The agency's schedule: which days, what times, and what each visit is for.
- [ ] The names and phone numbers of everyone who helps Dad, paid or not.
- [ ] Your own list of what Dad needs help with, one need to a line: personal care, the household, appointments and medications, and company and the things he enjoys. [1]

Compare

- [ ] Next to each need, who covers it now: the agency, a family member, Dad himself, or no one yet.
- [ ] Next to each line, “seen” if someone in the family has watched it happen, or “scheduled” if you're going on the paperwork.
- [ ] What your sister does for Dad that isn't on any schedule, by day if you can.
- [ ] Any need with no name beside it, written as a plain line and not as a complaint.
- [ ] Any place where two people, or a person and a paper, say different things. Keep both versions.

Ask

- [ ] Dad's own account of how the help is going, in his words. [2]
- [ ] Your sister's account of what she covers and how she's managing it. [2]
- [ ] For each “scheduled” or “not sure” line, who could tell you: the agency scheduler, the nurse, your sister, or Dad.
- [ ] Anything about his health or his medications, set aside as a question for his doctor or nurse. Change nothing on your own.
- [ ] A name next to each open line: who in the family will ask.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you gather, compare and ask. It doesn't tell you whether Dad's care is working or whether anything should change. A line marked “not sure” is something to check, and what the finished list means is for the people who assess him, and for the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've pulled the papers together and lined up what Dad needs against the help in place. The care interview goes through his situation area by area, so that comparison rests on a whole picture and not on memory, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The item marked 1 uses the four areas of help the Family Caregiver Alliance lists. The items marked 2 follow the National Institute on Aging's advice to check in with the older person and the other caregivers. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hiring In-Home Help
2. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities

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